

CITA01 – Foundations of City Studies
Final Exam
August 20, 2026
No Aids Allowed
Online Timed Synchronous Exam
Course Instructor: Olivia Bernard

This examination is worth 30% of your final grade. There are eight case-study questions, of which you must answer six. Responses should be approximately 250 words in length.

Your answers should draw on course materials, including assigned readings, lectures, class discussions, and relevant in-class video clips. Strong responses will demonstrate an understanding of key concepts, theories, models, major contributors, and relevant dates or time periods where appropriate. Your analysis should be grounded in course content rather than personal experience or opinion.

The examination will begin at 9:00 a.m. and end at 11:00 a.m. on August 20. You will have two hours to complete the exam. Please manage your time carefully and work strategically to ensure that you provide complete and well-developed responses to all six questions.

1. Course Overview

Identify the topic or case study that most changed how you think about cities. Explain what your understanding was before engaging with this material, what you learned, and how it changed your understanding of one urban issue discussed in the course. Use one course article to support your discussion.

2. Cities and Globalization/Global Cities

Toronto's Financial District, including the Toronto Stock Exchange and the Canadian headquarters of many multinational corporations, is often presented as evidence that Toronto is a global city. At the same time, many residents are concerned about housing affordability, transit access, and growing inequality between neighbourhoods.

Using Saskia Sassen's concept of global cities, explain how we should understand Toronto's development. Draw on Brenner and Keil (2015) to identify one limitation of the concept.

Sassen is useful for Toronto, but not because the Stock Exchange by itself “proves” a global city. For Sassen, global cities are places where the world economy is managed and coordinated. They concentrate financial markets, corporate headquarters, and specialized services such as law, accounting, and advertising. The Toronto Stock Exchange and the Canadian head offices of many multinational firms fit this model. Firms cluster downtown because they still need these producer services close by, even with new technology. Sassen also argues that a new core of banking and firm services replaces older manufacturing uses. That is a useful way to read Toronto’s shift toward finance. Sassen does not present

this as only a success story. She argues that inequality rises sharply in global cities. The internationalized sector can pay more for land, so neighbourhood shops and ordinary housing lose out. High-end offices, restaurants, and condos take their place. This helps explain Toronto's affordability crisis, weak transit access for many residents, and growing gaps between neighbourhoods.

Brenner and Keil (2015) point to a limit of the global city idea. It still focuses on the command core. They show that this clustering overloads existing land use. It also fuels speculative towers and luxury housing, downtown and beyond. The effects spill across the region through higher rents and displacement. Sassen still explains Bay Street. Brenner and Keil are more useful once you look at rent and displacement in the rest of the GTA.

3. Urban Inequality, Social Exclusion and Resistance

Québec's Bill 21 prohibits some public-sector employees, including teachers and police officers, from wearing visible religious symbols while at work. Supporters view the policy as necessary for state neutrality, while critics argue that it disproportionately affects religious minorities and limits their participation in public life.

Using the concept of social exclusion developed by Madanipour (2015), analyze how this policy may shape inclusion, belonging, and participation in Quebec. Explain one strength and one limitation of the social exclusion perspective.

Madanipour (2015) treats social exclusion as economic, political, and cultural. It is about unequal access to jobs, decision-making, and shared symbols of belonging. Bill 21 can be read through all three.

Culturally, the law treats some religious dress as out of place in public institutions. Teachers and police are very visible. Banning hijabs, turbans, or kippahs suggests that minority faiths do not fully belong in a "neutral" public. Politically, it limits who can represent the state. Economically, people may lose access to public-sector work unless they hide their faith. Madanipour argues that exclusion is sharpest when these three happen together. That is the risk here. A rule about symbols also becomes a rule about work and participation.

The useful part of Madanipour is that exclusion is not only about being poor. It shows that belonging depends on culture and power, not only income. The problem is that "exclusion" can describe almost any boundary, including ones that supporters of Bill 21 would defend as neutrality. Madanipour notes that some boundaries, like privacy at home, are normal. Supporters of Bill 21 would call this state neutrality, not exclusion. The framework does not always tell us how to separate a fair public rule from harmful exclusion. It also says little about gender. In practice the ban often falls hardest on Muslim women.

4. Urban Space and Morphology

During a trip across the GTA, Alex travels from downtown Toronto to Mississauga City Centre and then to Markham. Along the way, he observes office towers, shopping centres, condominium developments, highways, transit infrastructure, and residential neighbourhoods spread across the

region. Alex is surprised to find major employment, commercial, and residential centres located far beyond Toronto's downtown core.

Drawing on Burgess (2015 [1925/1998]) and Dear (2015), assess the extent to which Toronto is best understood through the Chicago School, the Los Angeles School, or a combination of both perspectives. Support your answer with examples from Toronto or the GTA.

Burgess still describes downtown. He does not describe the rest of Alex's trip. Burgess (2015 [1925/1998]) saw the city as concentric zones around a CBD. Uses compete, and inner zones invade the next ring through succession. Downtown Toronto still fits this. The Financial District is a strong core of office towers. Nearby condos and changing neighbourhoods show the centre still shaping land use close to it.

Alex is still right to be surprised. Mississauga City Centre and Markham are major employment, shopping, and housing places far beyond that core. Burgess assumed one organising centre. Dear (2015) argues that city-regions are fragmented. Global forces, not only local choice, shape different parts of the region. The CBD does not organise everything. Highways, suburban office parks, malls, and condo towers in Mississauga and Markham look more like the LA School. Growth is spread out, not a neat set of rings. Dear also stresses uneven development. Investment lands in some nodes and skips others. That helps explain strong suburban centres beside weaker areas, and inequality across the GTA. If the question is downtown, Burgess is enough. Alex's whole trip is not downtown, so Dear has to be in the answer too.

5. Creativity, Innovation and Economic Development

Toronto invests heavily in cultural events such as TIFF, Pride Toronto, and the Toronto Caribbean Carnival. City leaders argue that these events enhance the city's global reputation and attract tourism and investment. Critics argue that these strategies may contribute to rising housing costs and neighbourhood change.

Using Richard Florida's concept of the creative class, analyze Toronto's use of festivals and cultural events as an urban development strategy. Drawing on Heather McLean (2014), assess one way in which the benefits of creative-city strategies may not be experienced equally.

Florida treats the creative class as an economic group, not a cultural scene. Its members add value through ideas, not through owning factories. Cities try to attract them with technology, talent, and tolerance. Festivals are one way to do this. They brand a city as open and exciting, and they bring tourists and investment. TIFF, Pride Toronto, and the Toronto Caribbean Carnival fit this strategy. They sell Toronto as a global, diverse city. That matches Florida's claim that diversity and culture help growth. Toronto's Culture Plan (2003) made the same move. It treated culture as an economic engine, not only as public art.

McLean (2014) shows why the gains are not shared equally. She argues that creative-city events often stage diversity for middle-class professionals. They can also line up with plans to securitize neighbourhoods. Pride and Carnival can be turned into spectacles of "multicultural Toronto." The people who built those cultures, many of them racialized and working-class, may still face rising rents and displacement. McLean also says that since the mid-1990s Canadian arts funding has favoured mega-events that promise tourism. The city's reputation grows. Belonging does not grow in the same way.

Florida explains the city's bet on festivals. McLean's point is that the people who made Pride and Carnival are not the ones who reliably gain from that brand.

6. Reflections on Urban Design

In 2024, Toronto was described as Canada's loneliest city, with many residents reporting limited contact with neighbours and frequent feelings of loneliness. In response, *Rx for Social Connection: Public Space as a Strategy to Combat Loneliness* examined The Bentway as a Toronto case study. The project explored how public spaces can support mental health, belonging, and everyday social connection in a dense urban environment.

Choose one specific public space in Toronto that you have visited, passed through, or observed. What did you notice about how people use, avoid, or move through the space? Acting as an urban designer, identify one design issue that limits social connection and propose two concrete changes that would make the space more welcoming, visible, safe, and socially active. Draw on William Whyte, Jan Gehl, and/or Jane Jacobs in your response.

7. Artificial Intelligence and Urban Change

To address growing traffic congestion, the City of Toronto has partnered with the Ontario Vehicle Innovation Network to test AI-powered traffic management technologies on city streets. The initiative is part of the City's broader efforts to improve transportation and infrastructure planning.

Drawing on Al-Raei (2025) and Mattern (2020), discuss the role of artificial intelligence in shaping urban development. What does Toronto's use of AI technologies reveal about the opportunities and limitations of technology-driven approaches to urban challenges?

Al-Raei (2025) sees AI as a tool for sustainable urban development. Machines can read large data sets, find patterns, and help planners act faster. Traffic is one example. Fixed signal schedules cannot respond to changing congestion. AI systems can use cameras, sensors, and GPS in real time. Toronto's test with the Ontario Vehicle Innovation Network fits this. The city hopes technology will ease gridlock and support wider infrastructure planning.

Congestion is a real problem, so the efficiency argument is not empty. Congestion wastes time and fuel. Better timing of lights could move buses and cars more smoothly. Al-Raei also links this kind of efficiency to SDG 11, the goal of safer and more sustainable cities. Mattern (2020) shows the limit. A city is not a computer. If we treat streets as something to "optimize," we turn urban life into an engineering problem. Congestion is also about land use, who has space on the road, and who is counted in the data. Mattern says we must see who makes, owns, and uses urban data. Al-Raei himself warns that AI can embed bias in transport decisions and weaken accountability when systems are opaque.

Toronto already saw this with Sidewalk Labs. The smart-city project was cancelled after privacy and public-control concerns. An AI traffic pilot may help at intersections. It cannot, by itself, decide whose

mobility matters. The traffic pilot might still be worth testing. Mattern's warning is that a better signal time is not the same thing as a better city.

8. Reflections on Urban

As part of Toronto's efforts toward reconciliation, Indigenous place names, public art, and Indigenous design elements have become increasingly visible in parks, public spaces, and redevelopment projects across the city. These initiatives have prompted discussion about how Indigenous perspectives can be reflected in the planning and design of urban environments.

Drawing on Hall (2015 [2001]) and Nejad, Walker, and Newhouse (2020), discuss the role of urban planning in shaping cities. How might Indigenous placemaking transform the way urban spaces are planned, designed, and experienced?

Hall (2015 [2001]) argues that urban planning is never only technical. Early planning treated the city like architecture at a large scale. Experts drew a finished plan. They were not expected to work with the people they planned for. Later paradigms moved toward systems thinking, and then toward planners as managers and communicators. Hall still cares about who the plan is for, even after the later shift to managers and communicators.

In settler cities that role has been colonial. Nejad, Walker, and Newhouse (2020) argue that planning helped replace Indigenous places with settler cityscapes. Maps, surveys, and design made urban land look empty of Indigenous sovereignty. They call this a kind of urban emptiness. Indigenous people were pushed to the edge of the story of the city, even though many now live in Canadian cities.

Indigenous placemaking would change more than the look of parks. Nejad et al. say the process must be led by Indigenous people, using their own knowledge and methods. They should decide what is shown, how it is designed, and where it goes. Naming, public art, and design are not add-ons at the end. Toronto's turn toward Indigenous place names and art, such as Ookwemin Minising and Biidaasige Park, points in this direction. It can make hidden history visible in everyday space. Nejad et al. would not count new names and art as enough if Indigenous people are still outside the planning process. Hall's point about whose needs count is the same issue.